

PROLOGUE

ABANDONED LIBRARY

TAILLESS (OFFSTAGE)

I'm by the book! Yonder, guarding a book shelf.
The history of this library is an open book,
and I have used every trick in the book to
ensure this library does not end up history.

There were once human beings occupying this
library. They came from the outside world to
find refuge in these wondrous collections of
inks and papers. The desks teemed with colorful
bookmarks. The aisles brimmed with stories told
by those who have gone. They left their mark.

These giants are long gone. A mass extinction
event wiped out all of humanity. The library
was left abandoned. No animal has visited the
library since. Except us, the bugs.

Most were not interested in books. They came
simply to take back their land. Generations
after generations, the Firebrats led the charge
in dismantling the library. From the very
beginning, kids are taught to erase history.
The moment they hatched, larvae, nymphs, and
caterpillars are tasked with destroying any book
in sight. I'm here to do what's right and eat
these pesky kids! I judge a bug by its cowers.

TURNER, EAR, and LUKE squirm in.
TURNER leads with field guides. EAR
reads music. LUKE reads textbooks.

TAILLESS (OFFSTAGE) (CONT'D)

But some are not for my taste. You cannot judge
these bugs by their covers. In comes the first
bookworms to ever learn to read. They formed a
book club with the mission to archive as many
books as possible. By the book, for all books.
This is their founder. They soon find two other
bugs who can see the text for what they are.

BARK enters.

TAILLESS (OFFSTAGE) (CONT'D)

And there's a new reader found in the swarm.
The Book Club takes interest in this booklouse.
However, it takes more than reading to get in.
It takes bleeding for the best of books...

TURNER, EAR, and LUKE squirm out.

ACT I

SCENE 1

PERFORMANCE ART AISLE

The stage is a shelf with books
projected larger than life itself.

A laser pointer's dot (GERM) heads
to a book titled *The Audience*.
They bury themselves in the book.

BARK approaches the book.

GERM
Read *The Audience*!

BARK
What's an audience?
Jeremy Gerald Germain...

GERM
The Great!

BARK
Whatever, Germ... Bacteria get on my nerves.

GERM
Nerves, veins, brain, stomach, intestine-

BARK
I'm testing you. What's the audience?

GERM
The book says: "a group of people who place
their attention at a single entity. They see
and feel in the space together."

You spacing out again? Bark?

BARK
I want the "audience" to see me.

GERM
You'll get them, I'm sure.

BARK
How long does their attention span?

GERM
It says it is as long as bugs actually: Ninety
milliseconds.

BARK

We got ninety million seconds on this Earth.
This library. Let's make them count.

GERM

We could visit the math aisle.

BARK

Negative. We're borrowing this book. I'm sure
the Book Club would appreciate my share.

BARK buries himself in the book.

SCENE 2

QUIET AISLE

The stage is a part of a desk.

TURNER, EAR, and LUKE squirm in.

EAR

FAMILY IS EVERYTHING, YA KNOW?
FAMILY IS EVERYTHING. YA KNOW
NOT WHAT IS EVERYTHING.

LUKE

(Monotone)

I got to admit. This score you read this time
around. It's... fun.

TURNER

ELLIPSES, huh? Who wrote this?

EAR

A musical writer? The biography said they died
in complete obscurity in 2019. Curiosity...

TURNER

Sometimes, I wish humans never went extinct.

LUKE

It has been 65 million seconds.

EAR

Why, why would ya want giants walking amongst
us? Not even ants do we trust.

TURNER

Fortunately, y'all will trust a booklouse.
Look: I know it's been a while since we
welcomed anyone new in the Book Club.

LUKE

25 million seconds ago.

TURNER

Indeed. That moment was when I noticed your textbook learning, Luke. And see how much more fun this club has been since you've joined?

LUKE

Yes. I have been a ton of fun. I'm glad you noticed that I've been reading the textbook, *How to be Textbook Fun*.

EAR

The fun will be over, if one blows our cover.

LUKE

They would be our youngest member. Do you expect a kid to keep our secrets?

TURNER

I founded this club. I invite those I know who can read. Each new ally counts.

LUKE

Statistically, each member is a six percent increase in chance for our enemies to catch us.

TURNER

Where'd you get that number?

LUKE

I feel it in my six legs.

EAR

All filler, caterpillar.

LUKE

At least I won't grow up to be a butterfly like you, Ear.

EAR

Oh, beat it. I'm on my way to the ol' beetles club.

TURNER

Us moths, beetles, and cockroaches, we've got something in common. We will soar in the end!

EAR & LUKE

Your wings are filthy!

(Respectively laughing truly and dully)

Ha ha ha ha ha ha!

TURNER

When Bark gets here, I need to share the latest field guild I've read about birds.

LUKE

Eww...

EAR

Birds are nuisances in daylight, especially blackbirds in the dead of night.

LUKE

The Sun will rise. Where is your friend, Turner?

BARK reveals themself.

BARK

I'm here to turn the page!

EAR

Set the stage. Ya are late.

LUKE

The universe wants to answer my question.

BARK

I was uh... I was nearby, listening.

TURNER

I thought you'd be less awkward since we last met. *I told you to rehearse.*

BARK

Well, I did enter during a good... line. It's like... theatre!

EAR

What's theatre?

LUKE

It's that song you sang.

TURNER

Eww. Anyways, you know the cockroach nymph named Turner. This is our token beetle larva and moth caterpillar.

EAR & LUKE

Token?!

TURNER

It's comedy gold. I read *Provoke*, the joke book.

BARK

Is that a picture book full of cockroaches?

EAR

Ha, they roast ya. Ya ain't gonna coast this.

LUKE

I'm starting to like this kid.

TURNER

Well, you're in big kid territory now. Before you can join our book club, we request you bring a worthy offering.

LUKE takes out a notepad and jots down BARK's words.

BARK

I'd like to share with the Book Club... *The Audience*.

TURNER

I'm listening...

BARK

No no no. The audience is more than just one individual.

TURNER, EAR, LUKE

We're listening...

TURNER

What's the book about?

BARK

It's about how to capture the audience's—

LUKE

Using a booby trap?

BARK

Audience's *attention*.

EAR

So with rap?

TURNER

Pay attention.

LUKE

I have no such currency.

EAR

I ain't stacked like Johnny Cash.

TURNER

(Popping off)

Here's Johnny telling y'all to shut your mandibles.

(to BARK)

What's more to this story?

BARK

That's all I got.

TURNER

You did not read *The Audience* really well...

EAR

The story ya are redrafting is stuck in a rut.
The Audience kinda sucks.

LUKE

The Audience seems not to have a good grasp of the world based on your summary of its text.

BARK

Actually, I remember something else. One needs to capture the audience's attention in order for them not to text.

TURNER, EAR, and LUKE stare blankly.

BARK (CONT'D)

It says something about "phones." I'm not sure what a phone is either...

LUKE

(to TURNER)

Look. Bark is a phony.

EAR

Bark's barking up the wrong tree. Can't ya see?

GERM gets on EAR's face.

TURNER

I see...

EAR

Uh?

LUKE

(Still monotone)

Ah! A bacterium!

EAR

EEEEEEE! Get it off me!

LUKE slaps EAR with the notepad.
They try to stomp on the erratic laser pointer's dot.

EAR (CONT'D)

My antenna! Ya stupid bug.

LUKE

You cannot grow antennas yet, you uneducated larva.

EAR

Ya brain pillars are made up of moron.
Caterpillar.

GERM

(Only heard by BARK)

You are all kids. You don't know squat.

TURNER

I'll get the bacteria swatter!

BARK

No, I got this.

BARK puts out their palms.

GERM gets in BARK's palms.

BARK swiftly closes their hands.

TURNER

Yuck. Perhaps it is a bad hour to do this.
We'll give you another chance. Next time, bring
something of sustenance and not *The Audience*.

BARK

I don't get to see y'all's Secret Library?

TURNER

Not yet.

LUKE

You'll like its atmosphere...

EAR

We think ya'd wreck it, we fear.

TURNER

Ear, your treatment of Bark disgusts me.

Excuse me, I've gotta run to the toilet. I'm
starving.

LUKE

Don't fall in or we'll have to fish you out
with my submarine again.

EAR

That submarine got yellower and yellower.

BARK

While you're eating out of the toilet bowl, you
might as well flush *The Audience* down it.

TURNER

While we won't give *The Audience* another chance, we're giving you and your character it. We'll leave you with this: the Book Club motto.

TURNER, EAR, LUKE

Consume knowledge, not books.

TURNER, EAR, and LUKE squirm out.

GERM

They are so full of crap.

BARK

You started a crap show. What was that?!

GERM

Justice. Remember reading *Killing Floor*?

BARK

That's a reach.

GERM

Jack Reacher went all vigilante like I did. I want you to reach all bug kind.

BARK

You know what I want to reach? The center of the Earth.

GERM

That's in the sci-fi aisle under Verne.

BARK

No, I must go to the library's backroom.

GERM

The backroom? That's where the monster lurks.

BARK

Yes. Novels of epic proportions.

GERM

I mean... the Tailless Scorpion.

BARK

Legend says that they prey on book-eating bugs.

GERM

You do that all the time!

BARK

Did. I no longer eat books. I eat knowledge.

GERM

Well, they still cannot tell you apart from the other kids.

BARK

They don't have to. We'll be in and out. You'll be on lookout.

GERM

I'll be a fly on the wall?

BARK

Too loud.

GERM

Butterfly on the wall.

BARK

Better.

GERM

Then sting them like a bee.

BARK

Gee, your mind buzzes.

GERM

I read Muhammad Ali's biography.

BARK

I'll give Tailless a knockout punch.

GERM

You'll end up in their punch like the Caribbean folklore about a vampire witch, Soucouyant.

BARK

We're getting off tropic here. I'm sailing to the edge of the world like Sinbad the Sailor.

GERM

You'll sink like Pequod in *Moby Dick*.

BARK walks in place.

Aisles of the library zip by.

GERM (CONT'D)

You're such a douche. You are not going to come back from this. This is no hero's journey. You're not getting passed the exposition.

SCENE 3

BACKROOM

The stage is dark and mysterious.

GERM jumps out of BARK's hand.

BARK

We're here.

GERM

It looks unnerving as I imagined.

Giant footsteps are heard moving.

GERM (CONT'D)

It sounds unnerving beyond my imagination.

BARK

Finally! Something gets on your nerves.

GERM

I have no nerves. *Unicellular organism*. You got some nerves, multi.

BARK

I admit. I am kind of nervous.

GERM

Trust the instinct.

BARK goes all in.

GERM (CONT'D)

Your bug instinct is supposed to tell you to run away!

BARK

Oh... I was following a bacteria's. To go inside, where I am not supposed to.

GERM

And to multiply, but you cannot form an army.

BARK

I visited the math aisle and also read *The Art of War*. "Appear weak when you are strong, and strong when you are weak."

TAILLESS's shadow goes by. They only ever appear as a shadow.

GERM

You appear weak. So that makes you strong?

BARK

(Nervously)

Precisely, but it wouldn't hurt if the Tailless Scorpion does not see either side of me...

Bark walks in place.

The backroom holds banned books.

GERM

Out of Darkness. The Hate U Give.

BARK

Take it lightly. I have no hate in my salivary glands.

GERM

I'm spitting out book titles that I'm seeing here: *To Kill a Mockingbird*.

BARK

I'm sure the others would love to do that.

GERM

Of Mice and Men.

BARK

Can we stop it with the predators?

GERM

And Tango Makes Three.

BARK

(Observing the book cover)

Warmer. What kind of birds are they?

GERM

Gay birds.

BARK

The only acceptable birds. Warmer.

GERM

All Boys Aren't Blue.

BARK

I need something redder.

GERM

Fahrenheit 451.

BARK goes up and touches the book.

GERM (CONT'D)

You're on fire!

BARK's hands feel like they are on fire. They fall back, trying not to scream in pain.

BARK

My palps are!

GERM

Don't move a muscle. I'll look for a piece of literature that may help.

GERM goes out and looks for aid.

BARK moves about, soon stumbling upon a plastic water bottle.

BARK

Water?!

BARK punches a hole through the bottle. They feel relieved.

The bottle suddenly bursts and washes BARK downstage.

BARK notices a booklet titled *How to Put Bookworms on Hold*.

GERM swims in.

GERM

There you are! I've been looking everywhere for you in this ocean. I found a booklet called *First Aid*, but it can only be administered to those with thick skin.

BARK

I'm not thin-skinned. You were taking too long.

GERM

I can't help that your nymph legs cover more ground than my *flagellum* could.

BARK

I spot a red flag.

GERM

Redder than that book about book burning?

BARK points.

GERM (CONT'D)

Oh... *How to Put Bookworms on Hold*. Okay. Hold yourself together. I'm going in!

Oh no... I'm out.

BARK

Read.

GERM

Need?

BARK

Need?

GERM (CONT'D)

Do you need to hear all this?

BARK (CONT'D)

You're right. I've got to stop holding my
breath for you.

BARK puts their head under water.

GERM

Alright. This booklet lists instructions on how
to kill booklice, like you...

I'm sorry to have to read that. Listen: 99.99%
of my kin have been constantly wiped out in the
palms of these humans. I get you.

TAILESS roars in the distance.

GERM (CONT'D)

Let's not have the Tailless Scorpion get you.
You'll be the 0.01% who lives to tell the tale!

GERM hitches a ride on BARK. They
soon run by a pesticide bottle.

TAILESS's shadow looms.

GERM (CONT'D)

Quick. Cover yourself in pesticide!

BARK

What's pesticide?!

GERM

Based on the booklet: its remnants burnt your
palps!

BARK

Pesticide sounds like suicide!

GERM

This bottle says that it expired long ago.

BARK

Let me expire.

GERM

I will not. Punch the bottle.

Ugh. BARK GERM (CONT'D)
 Muhammad Ali it!

BARK punches the pesticide bottle.

The bottle bursts, flooding the stage.

TAILLESS screams and runs off.

SCENE 4

AISLE OF NOWHERE

BARK lies on the wet stage.

 BARK GERM
Everything sure stings like a You're floating like a
bee! butterfly!

 BARK (CONT'D)
Either way, the Book Club won't let this slide.

 GERM
What do you mean?

 BARK
I came out with no books.

 GERM
That's perfectly fine! I have read dozens of
book in that backroom. I can pass on the notes.

 BARK
I... I don't want to hear them.

 GERM
Don't you want to hear back from the Book Club?

 BARK
The club, yes. The books...

 GERM
Reading comprehension is difficult. But you can
make out the words unlike 99.99% of your fellow
insects.

 BARK
Do you want to remember those who wiped out
99.99% of your kind?

 GERM
Of course. I wanted vengeance. However, those
darn viruses beat us to them.